Alida Angafor

Massachusetts, USA · alidaangafor@gmail.com
Personal Website: alidaangafor.com

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Areas of specialization: Philosophy of cosmology, philosophy of time, epistemology (self-locating belief), Philosophy of physics, philosophy of science, philosophy of mind, metaphysics of the self

My work asks how the observer fits into physical theory. I am interested in what the gap between the block universe and our experience of time's passage can reveal about how we understand subjective experience. Additionally, I am interested understanding how observers should reason about where and when they are in the universe.

EDUCATION

M.A., Philosophy · Central European University, Vienna, Austria · 2024–2026

- Thesis: "Understanding the First-Person Viewpoint from the Third: Some Remarks on Being Someone." Supervisor: Lisa Doerksen.
- The thesis argues that the subjectivity of experience, the fact that every experience is for someone, is grounded in a persisting subject rather than a self constituted only within momentary experience. The question of what it is to occupy a perspective is where my work on self-locating belief and the place of the observer in physical theory begins.
- Graduate coursework: Laws of Nature (Ferenc Huoranszki); Objectivity (Maria Kronfeldner); Advanced Epistemology and Beliefs and Desires (Katalin Farkas); Epistemology (Phyllis Pearson).

B.A., Philosophy and Sociology, Minor in Astronomy · Dartmouth College, Hanover, NH · 2017–2021

- Astronomy minor coursework in mathematics, physics, and astronomy, which gave me grounding in the observational and physical science that philosophy of cosmology works with.
- Capstone project: *Knowledge Through Imagination*, supervised by Peter Lewis, a philosopher of physics.
- Relevant coursework: Realism vs. Anti-Realism (Amie Thomasson); Philosophy of Imagination (Amie Thomasson); Mind and Psychology (John Kulvicki); Research Methods.

ADDITIONAL TRAINING

- CS 2881R: AI Safety, Harvard University (Prof. Boaz Barak), external participant, Fall 2026

PLANNED COURSEWORK

- PH 470: Philosophy of Physics, Boston University (Spring 2027, Tuesday and Thursday, 3:30–4:45 PM)
- AST 0010: Wanderers in Space, Tufts University (Spring 2027, Monday and Wednesday, 6:00–7:15 PM)

WORKS IN PROGRESS

Self-locating belief and the experience of time · PhD research project in development

- Asks what the mismatch between the block universe and our experience of time's passage implies about the reality of subjective experience, and whether there is a rational way to set self-locating credences. These questions carry over to cosmology, where what our evidence supports can depend on where and when we find ourselves as observers.

"Where Do We Go Between Experiences? Existential Subjectivity and the Self in Experience" · Journal article in preparation, drawn from M.A. thesis

- Distinguishes existential subjectivity, the persisting subject that experience depends on, from experiential subjectivity, the self as it shows up within experience. Argues that a subject cannot be just its conscious experiences, and so gives an account of the persisting observer that self-locating reasoning takes for granted.

"Misalignment as Evidence of Human Error, Not Machine Agency" · Independent research project, 2026

- A question in the philosophy of science about what observed behavior licenses us to infer about a system's underlying nature. Argues that attributions of agency to AI systems rest on Dennett's intentional stance, which cannot distinguish genuine from as-if agency, and that misalignment reflects human optimization choices and error rather than machine agency.

"Whose Lie Is It? Agency Attribution in AI Deception Evaluations" · Independent research project, 2026

- Argues that describing model outputs as deceptive rather than erroneous presupposes a thick notion of agency (belief, goal ownership, a first-person standpoint) that current evaluations assume but do not test. Includes a two-experiment protocol testing perspective invariance and goal ownership, bringing questions about the first-person perspective into empirical method.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Research Assistant to Prof. Brad Skow · Department of Linguistics and Philosophy, MIT · Jan–Mar 2021

- Supported research in the philosophy of science on how the sciences understand cause and effect, summarizing the relevant literature and presenting weekly on our progress.

Research Assistant to Prof. Maron Greenleaf · Department of Anthropology, Dartmouth College · 2021

- Produced a historical literature review on development, inclusion, and exclusion, tracing how a field's central concepts changed over time.

Human Development Research Fellow · John Sloan Dickey Center for International Understanding, Dartmouth College · 2018–2021

- Completed six terms of paid research assistantships on faculty-led, field-based projects aimed at alleviating poverty in low-income countries.

TEACHING

Astronomy Teaching Assistant · Appalachian Mountain Club, Bretton Woods, NH · Jun–Aug 2019

- Traveled hut to hut across the White Mountains giving public astronomy lectures and leading night observing sessions, explaining the structure and scale of the universe to general audiences, including children.

Teaching Assistant · Dartmouth Leadership Attitudes and Behaviors Program · Jan–Apr 2019

- Facilitated structured discussions on values and ethical reasoning in leadership.

FELLOWSHIPS AND SCHOLARSHIPS

- Human Development Fellowship, John Sloan Dickey Center for International Understanding, Dartmouth College, 2018–2021
- Central European University Master's Scholarship (tuition and stipend), 2024–2026
- Dartmouth College Undergraduate Scholarship (partial tuition, room and board), 2017–2021

- Federal Pell Grant (partial tuition), 2017–2021
- Abramson Foundation Scholarship Award, 2017–2021
- Future Business Leaders of America Scholarship Award, 2017–2021
- Black Youth Achievement Award, Springbrook High School, 2014

GRANTS

- PLATO Grant for Philosophy Programs, 2017. Funded a philosophy essay competition I organized for peers at Columbia Heights Educational Campus.

SERVICE AND COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT

Therapist Understudy · Nashoba Learning Group, Massachusetts · Sep 2026–present

- Deliver one-to-one instruction based on applied behavior analysis to students with autism spectrum and related disorders, recording behavioral and skills data systematically to track each student's progress.

Child Welfare Caseworker · Chaffee County Department of Human Services, Salida, CO · Nov 2023–Aug 2024

- Made decisions about children's safety from evidence that was incomplete and still unfolding, weighing each person's account against what could be observed and documented.

Team Manager · Southwest Conservation Corps · Mar–Nov 2023

- Led conservation field crews through long seasons of outdoor project work, making steady decisions in changing conditions and holding the group together when the work was hard.

Field Staff · Elements Wilderness Therapy; Pacific Quest

- Lived and worked in the field alongside young people in wilderness therapy programs, supporting their daily routines and the therapeutic goals set by their clinical teams.

MEMBERSHIPS AND ORGANIZATIONS

- Minorities and Philosophy (MAP), Central European University chapter, member, 2024–2026
- Central European University Philosophy Club, member, 2024–2026
- Dartmouth College Philosophy Club, member, 2018–2021
- Columbia Heights Educational Campus Philosophy Club, founder, 2015–2017

SKILLS

- **Languages:** English (native), Spanish (conversational), German (elementary)
- **Programming:** Python, C++, HTML, CSS

REFERENCES

Available upon request